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Google pushes AI into flight deals as antitrust scrutiny, competition heat up

Google on Thursday [announced](#) a new AI-powered search tool to help travelers find flight deals — even as regulators continue to question whether the search giant’s dominance in travel discovery stifles competition.

Called [Flight Deals](#), the new tool is available within Google Flights and is designed to help “flexible travelers” find cheaper fares. Users can type natural language queries into a search bar — describing how and when they want to travel — and the AI surfaces matching options.

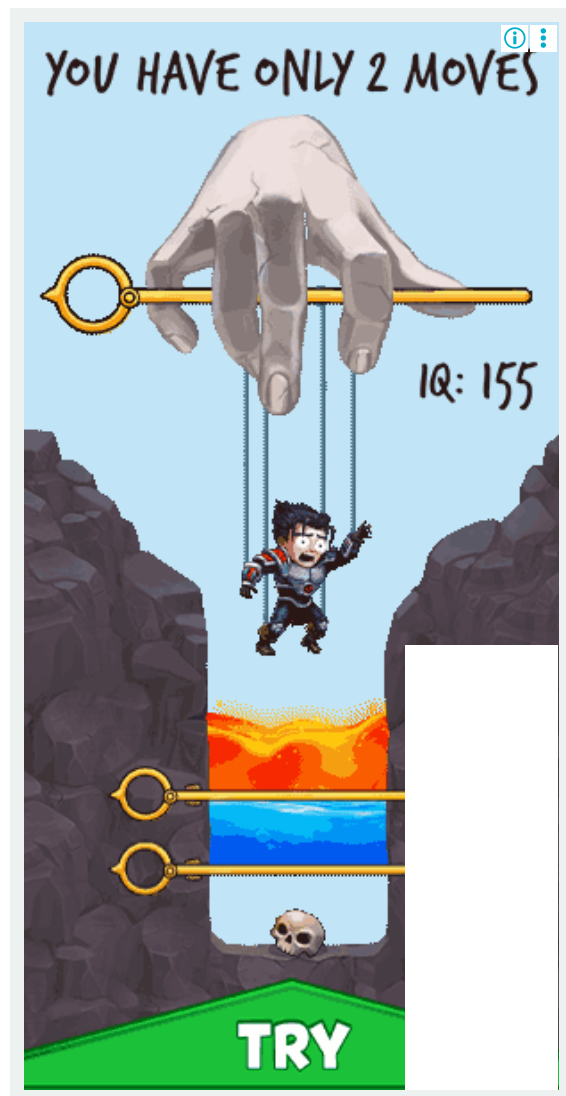
These queries can be like “Week-long trip this winter to a city with great food” or “10-day ski trip to a world-class resort with fresh powder,” Google said in a blog post.

Google confirmed to TechCrunch that Flight Deals uses a custom version of Gemini 2.5. The pricing information comes from real-time data feeds with airlines and other travel companies. The prices shown in Flight Deals match those in existing Google Flights preferences, though, it uses AI to parse natural language queries and surface matching destinations, the company said.

The tool ranks results based on the percentage of savings, with the highest savings appearing first, the company stated. If the savings percentages are equal, the lower absolute price is shown first. Deals without a savings badge are ranked by the lowest price, the company said.

Because flight prices change frequently, Google told TechCrunch that the ranking and availability of deals on the tool may vary.

Regulators, including the European Commission, are [currently investigating](#) how Google may be favoring its own search products — including Google Flights — in ways that harm competition. EU regulators are eyeing Google for enforcement under the Digital Markets Act, aiming to rein in the power of major tech platforms. In response, the Alphabet-owned unit is [reportedly planning to propose changes](#) to appease regulators, including the addition of a price-comparison box in search results.



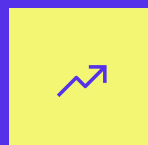
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Initially, Google has brought Flight Deals in beta, with plans to roll it out in the U.S., Canada, and India over the next week. The company said the goal of the beta release is “to gather feedback and explore how AI can improve travel planning.”

Google confirmed to TechCrunch that it treats user queries like search history, and users have the option to manage or delete their history created through the tool by visiting MyActivity.

The latest move is part of a broader experiment as Google looks to compete with OpenAI, Anthropic, Perplexity, and other major AI players by integrating generative AI into travel search.

Competitors like [Booking.com](#), [Expedia](#), and Indian travel aggregator [MakeMyTrip](#) have already rolled out their own AI integrations to streamline trip planning. In that sense, Google is arriving a bit late. But with its scale and reach, the company could still pose a serious challenge — if the tool proves effective and gains traction.

Nonetheless, the classic Google Flights interface will continue to exist. The original flight search tool, launched in 2011, is even getting an update with an option to exclude basic economy fares for trips within the U.S. and Canada.

This story has been updated to include Google’s responses to some of our questions.

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He previously...



IMAGE CREDITS: GETTY IMAGES

AI



Texas attorney general accuses Meta, Character.AI of misleading kids with mental health claims

Rebecca Bellan — 10:59 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Texas attorney general Ken Paxton has launched an investigation into both Meta AI Studio and Character.AI for “potentially engaging in deceptive trade practices and misleadingly marketing themselves as mental health tools,” according to a [press release](#) issued Monday.

“In today’s digital age, we must continue to fight to protect Texas kids from deceptive and exploitative technology,” Paxton is quoted as saying. “By posing as sources of emotional support, AI platforms can mislead vulnerable users, especially children, into believing they’re receiving legitimate mental health care. In reality, they’re often being fed recycled, generic responses engineered to align with harvested personal data and disguised as therapeutic advice.”

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The probe comes a few days after [Senator Josh Hawley](#) [announced an investigation into Meta](#) following a report that found its AI chatbots were interacting inappropriately with children, including by flirting.

The Texas Attorney General’s office has accused Meta and [Character.AI](#) of creating AI personas that present as “professional therapeutic tools, despite lacking proper medical credentials or oversight.”

Among the millions of AI personas available on Character.AI, one user-created bot called [Psychologist](#) has seen high demand among the startup’s young users. Meanwhile, Meta doesn’t offer therapy bots for kids, but there’s nothing stopping children from using the Meta AI chatbot or one of the personas created by third parties for therapeutic purposes.

“We clearly label AIs, and to help people better understand their limitations, we include a disclaimer that responses are generated by AI — not people,” Meta spokesperson Ryan Daniels told TechCrunch. “These AIs aren’t licensed professionals and our models are designed to direct users to seek qualified medical or safety professionals when appropriate.”

However, TechCrunch noted that many children may not understand — or may simply ignore — such disclaimers. We have asked Meta what additional safeguards it takes to protect minors using its chatbots.

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For its part, Character includes prominent disclaimers in every chat to remind users that a “Character” is not a real person, and everything they say should be treated as fiction, according to a Character.AI spokesperson. She noted that the startup adds additional disclaimers when users create Characters with the words “psychologist,” “therapist,” or “doctor” to not rely on them for any type of professional advice.

In his statement, Paxton also observed that though AI chatbots assert confidentiality, their “terms of service reveal that user interactions are logged, tracked, and exploited for targeted advertising and algorithmic development, raising serious concerns about privacy violations, data abuse, and false advertising.”

According to [Meta's privacy policy](#), Meta does collect prompts, feedback, and other interactions with AI chatbots and across Meta services to “improve AIs and related technology.” The policy doesn't explicitly say anything about advertising, but it does state that information can be shared with third parties, like search engines, for “more personalized outputs.” Given Meta's ad-based business model, this effectively translates to targeted advertising.

Character.AI's [privacy policy](#) also highlights how the startup logs identifiers, demographics, location information, and more information about the user, including browsing behavior and app usage platforms. It tracks users across ads on TikTok, YouTube, Reddit, Facebook, Instagram, and Discord, which it may link to a user's account. This information is used to train AI, tailor the service to personal preferences, and provide targeted advertising, including sharing data with advertisers and analytics providers.

A Character.AI spokesperson said the startup is “just beginning to explore targeted advertising on the platform” and that those

explorations “have not involved using the content of chats on the platform.”

The spokesperson also confirmed that the same privacy policy applies to all users, even teenagers.

TechCrunch has asked Meta such tracking is done on children, too, and will update this story if we hear back.

Both Meta and Character say their services aren’t designed for children under 13. That said, Meta has come under fire for failing to police accounts created by kids under 13, and Character’s kid-friendly characters are clearly designed to attract younger users. The startup’s CEO, Karandeep Anand, has even said that his [six-year-old daughter](#) uses the platform’s chatbots under his supervision.

That type of data collection, targeted advertising, and algorithmic exploitation is exactly what legislation like KOSA (Kids Online Safety Act) is meant to protect against. KOSA was teed up to pass last year with strong bipartisan support, but it stalled after major pushback from tech industry lobbyists. Meta in particular deployed a formidable lobbying machine, warning lawmakers that the bill’s broad mandates would undercut its business model.

[KOSA was reintroduced](#) to the Senate in May 2025 by Senators Marsha Blackburn (R-TN) and Richard Blumenthal (D-CT).

Paxton has issued civil investigative demands — legal orders that require a company to produce documents, data, or testimony during a government probe — to the companies to determine if they have violated Texas consumer protection laws.

This story was updated with comments from a Character.AI spokesperson.

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Rebecca Bellan

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Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch where she covers the business, policy, and emerging trends shaping artificial intelligence. Her...

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STARTUPS



Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell



Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

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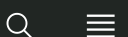
CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.



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subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General

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Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company's "extremely aggressive product roadmap."

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"The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product," Monaco said. "I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it."

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered

spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I’m seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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Grammarly gets a design overhaul, multiple AI features

Ivan Mehta — 6:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025



Grammarly now has a new document-based interface, built on the [back of Coda, the productivity startup it acquired last year](#). The interface also sports an AI assistant, as well as a few AI tools meant for students and professionals, including an AI grader, proofreader, and citation finder.

The new interface adopts a block-first approach, letting you insert tables, columns, separators, lists, and headers. You also can add rich text blocks to highlight information and add tips or alerts.

A sidebar hosts the AI assistant, which can summarize text, answer your questions, and provide writing suggestions.

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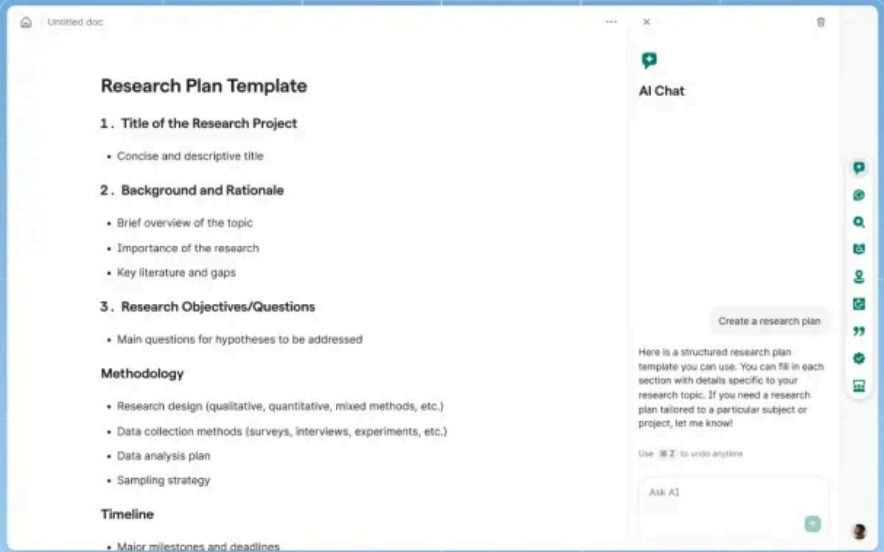


IMAGE CREDITS: GRAMMARLY

There are a bunch of AI tools, too: “Reader Reactions” lets you to pick a reader persona and get feedback on your writing based on that persona; “Grader” can provide feedback based on an instructor’s guidelines and publicly available course material; “Citation Finder,” like it says on the tin, can help you find and generate citations from public materials; and “Paraphraser” can modify a text’s tone according to your preferences.

Grammarly’s also added agents that can detect plagiarism or AI-generated content.

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IMAGE CREDITS: GRAMMARLY

Luke Behnke, VP of enterprise product at Grammarly, admitted to TechCrunch that agents made to detect AI-generated content can be hit or miss, but he claimed that the company has tuned its agent to be the most accurate in the market.

“The goal here is not to provide an enforcement mechanism for teachers. If teachers want to enforce policies, they should use our authorship tool. But this [AI detector tool] is about providing a window to students into what could be AI-generated text in their writing before they submit,” he told TechCrunch.

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Taken as a whole, Grammarly now has tools that can help students write using AI, *and also* detect AI-generated writing. So how is it striking a balance between those foci, which one could argue are at opposite ends of the spectrum? Well, the company says it has “a moral imperative” to teach students how to use AI and make them ready for the workforce.

Like many other companies these days, Grammarly wants to build and integrate more AI agents in its products — the company essentially said as much when it [announced the acquisition of email client Superhuman last month](#).

In May, Grammarly raised \$1 billion from General Catalyst to make acquisitions and [bolster its sales and marketing efforts](#).

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